

The New Design Frontier

The widest-ranging report to date
examining design's impact on business



Explore the astronomical impact design has on business

InVision surveyed thousands of companies to explore the relationship between design practices and business performance. We found that those dominating their industries are the ones treating the screen like the most important place on Earth.

In fact, companies with high design maturity see cost savings, revenue gains, and brand and market position improvements as a result of their design efforts. What we uncovered about the practices of these enterprises offers a blueprint for business leaders to ensure their design dollars are invested for maximum returns.

With more than 2,200 designers interviewed around the globe, this is the widest-ranging report of its kind, and its findings will transform the way you work.



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Unearthing the insights

In Fall 2018, InVision surveyed designers from more than 2,200 organizations around the world to explore how companies can create better business outcomes with design. We asked questions orbiting around company demographics, design team resources, executive involvement, practices, outcomes, and more.

To develop the survey, we audited existing design maturity models, consulted industry analysts, conducted qualitative research with designers in the field, and tapped the insights of our own in-house experts. What we came up with is unlike any maturity model to date. What's different?

It's the largest global study of design in business.

Other studies have been conducted (most notably in the United Kingdom and Denmark), and McKinsey recently produced a fantastic analysis using millions of data points, but from only 300 companies. This is the first study we know of that compares the design behaviors of thousands of companies around the globe, from small businesses to large enterprises, NGOs to the Fortune 500.

It examines design in companies like yours, whatever yours may be.

The number of companies in this study makes it possible to slice and dice the data endlessly with sample sizes large enough to draw statistically valid conclusions about the behaviors of subgroups within the overall design community, including differences by region, industry, company type, and more.

It was developed with analytical rigor.

We employed advanced statistical methods to identify the trends behind the trends. These techniques make it possible to look across hundreds of design-related behaviors, activities, and resources, and unearth the core principles that make a difference in achieving significant business benefits through design.

What does this mean for you?

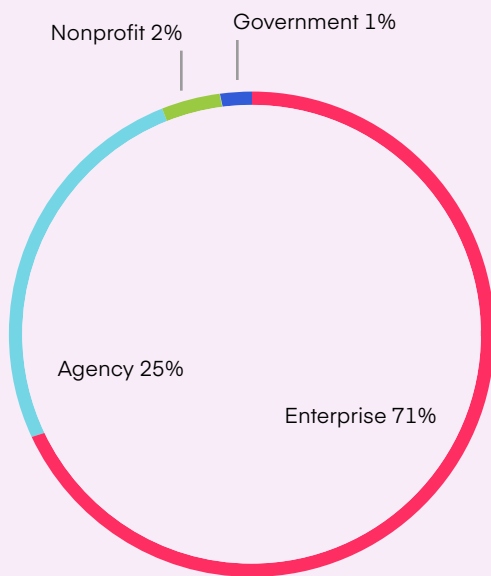
After analyzing the data using regression and factor analysis, we mapped design-forward characteristics across five maturity levels. We found that design propels substantial business impact. In fact, companies with high design maturity in our model are more likely to see cost savings, revenue gains, productivity gains, speed to market, and brand and market position improvements through their design efforts.

But it takes more than just headcount. At companies with serious intentions to use design as a business-enabler, key partners, executives, and employees are more involved in the design process. Read on to unearth the secrets of design maturity.

The largest design maturity study

2,200 companies

Thousands of companies, including large enterprises, small businesses, agencies, and even government and non-profit organizations, shared how design makes an impact.



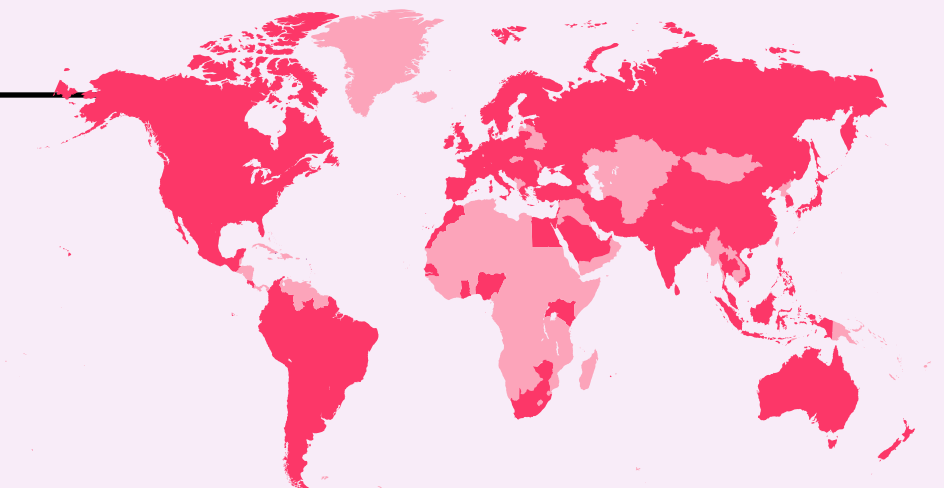
**Percentages have been rounded and may not equal 100%.*

24 industries

Every industry under the sun reported on the impact of design to their organizations. There's a view for aerospace, advertising, insurance, education, and everything in between.

77 countries

Those surveyed included businesses spanning the globe, from North America to Latin America, Europe to Asia.



Analysis

**"Research is creating
new knowledge."**

- Neil Armstrong



Limitations: As with any research, there are limitations that you should be aware of. Survey participants were selected from InVision's contact database, which includes current clients, past clients, and people who have signed up for marketing communications. That means this isn't a random sample. The analysis is based on self-reported data from individuals who may have biased responses or may not have a complete understanding of design practices in their company.

Where do you fit in the design maturity universe?

We found that among the most design-forward organizations, design is well integrated into the product development process, with the senior team, and in the product roadmap. In fact, there is a direct correlation between the number of business benefits that design drives and the degree of organizational adoption of design. Organizations that embrace and integrate design practices also report more positive business outcomes, including when it comes to product, position, profit, and more.

When organizations establish the right conditions for design and make room for it in core processes, they also experience deeper customer understanding, bolder exploration and experimentation, and more informed decisions vetted through the continuous testing and learning process design enables.

We identified five natural levels of design maturity, with Level 1 being the least mature and Level 5 employing the most mature design practices: Producers, Connectors, Architects, Scientists, and Visionaries. We'll get into more detail with them later, but for now, let's explore a deeper look at design practices.

These are the behaviors—and their outcomes—of organizations defining design in business today.

"Intelligence is the ability to adapt to change."

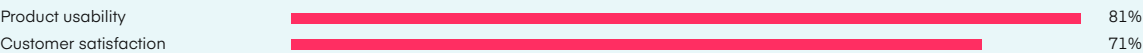
- Stephen Hawking

Rocket-powered results

Leading companies are using design to drive efficiency, profit, and position. In fact, nearly three quarters of companies say they have improved customer satisfaction and usability through design.

“Our design team has had proven impact on: ”

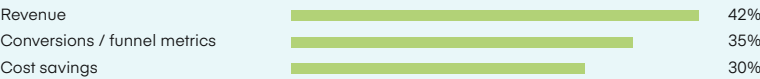
Product quality



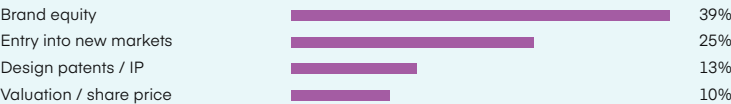
Operational efficiency



Business profitability



Market position



**Based on 2,229 respondents*

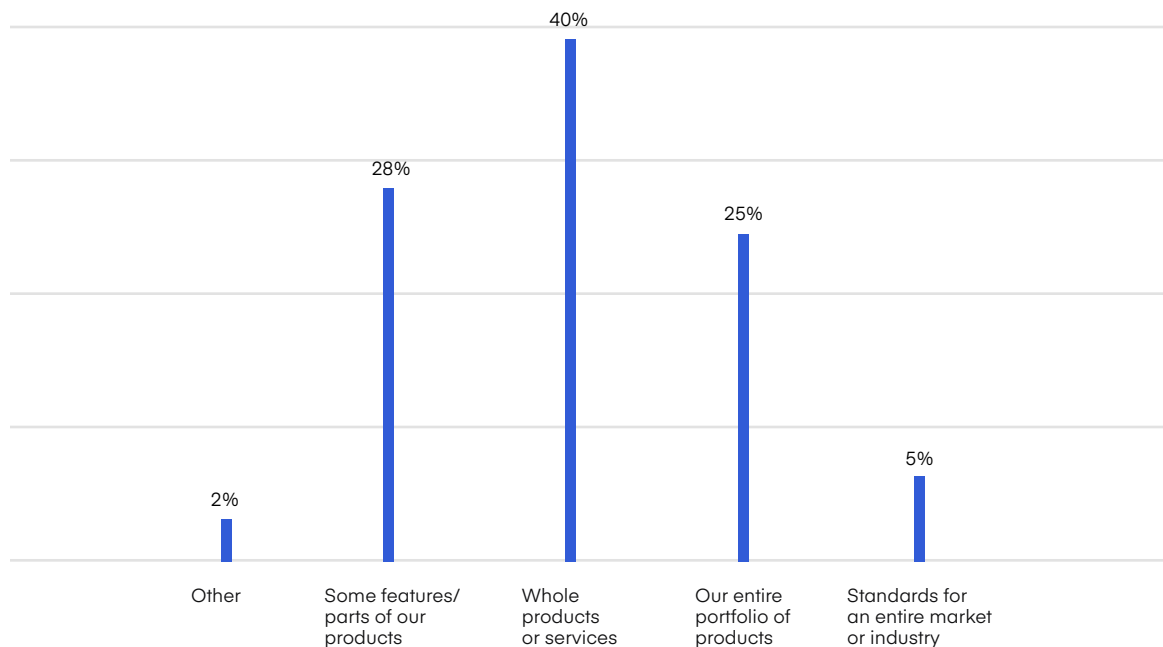
Powering product & strategy



It's great when a company has success stories where design has produced concrete business benefits. It's even more powerful when that happens across the portfolio and throughout the company, repeatedly and sustainably.

Fewer than a third of companies use design to merely work on features. **Instead, design is reshaping product development and corporate portfolios at nearly 70% of companies.**

"Our design team has shaped: "



**Based on 2,180 respondents*

Adoption is crucial

Involvement from key stakeholders signals how extensively a company has adopted design, but deeper forms of adoption—like participating in user research, working in shared software, and developing product ideas jointly—remain less common. **Design is well integrated into every step of product decision-making and evolution at about two-thirds of companies.**

Based on responses to multiple questions:

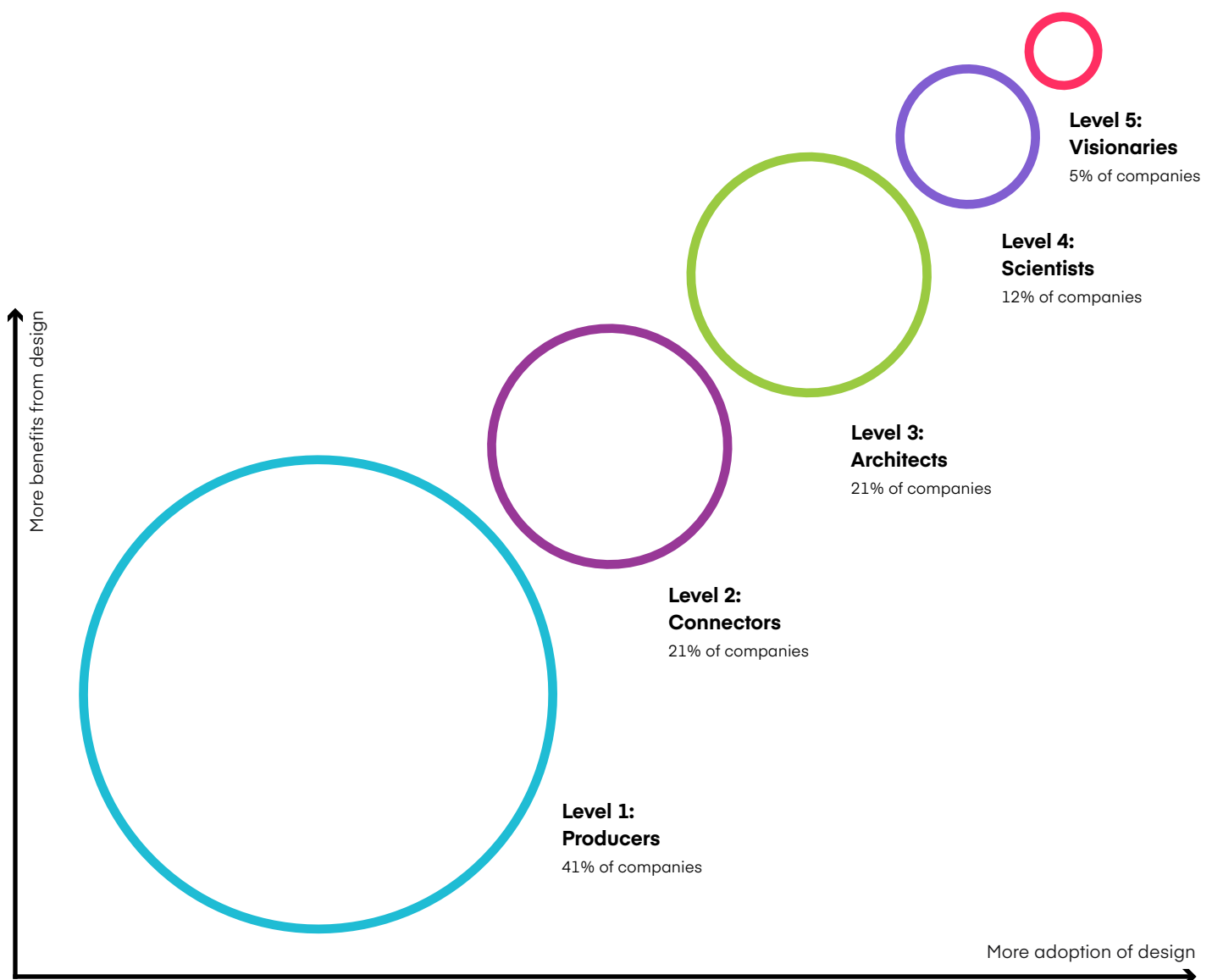
- "Our company's top executives (check all that apply):"
- "Employees in our company (check all that apply):"
- "Our design team collaborates with key partners like product managers and engineers in the following ways:"



**Based on 2,229 respondents*

Few benefit most

A select group of companies are receiving the most value from design for business. Although nearly 80% of companies include design on projects often or almost always, **just 5% are empowering design for the greatest benefits**, and 41% have significant room to grow.



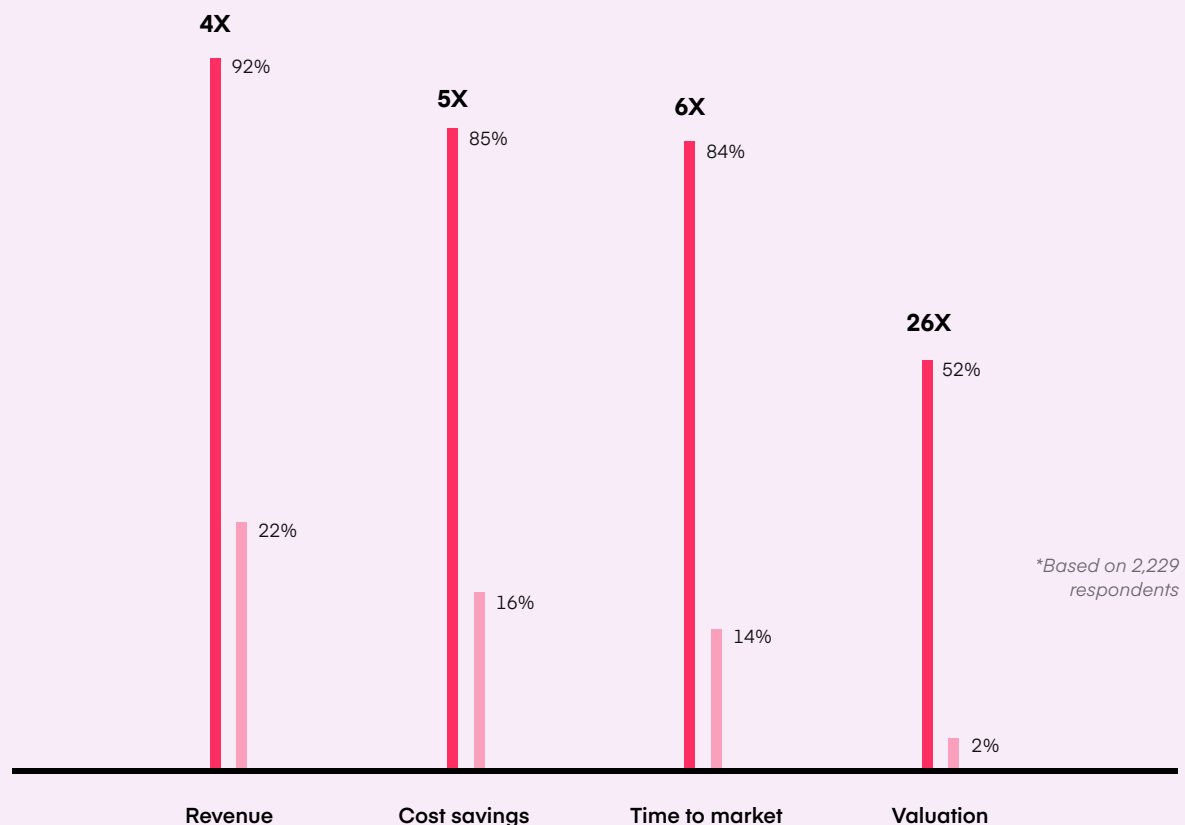
*Based on 2,229 respondents

Maturity is reflected in stellar results

So how does this investment in design relate to the bottom line? It's not just qualitative business results, like customer satisfaction and loyalty, that design has an effect on. **Companies in our study reported that when design takes center stage, it can have a direct impact on tangible business results, like revenue, valuation, and time to market.**

"Our design team has had proven impact on: "

- Level 5 companies
- Level 1 companies

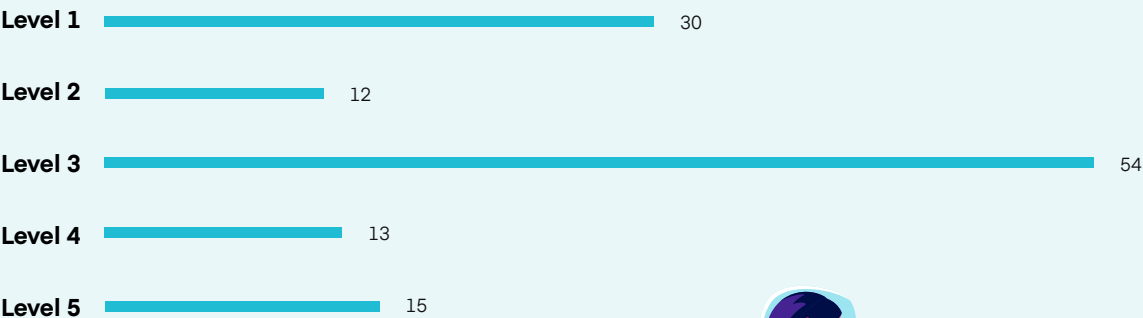


Biggest teams don't always shine brightest

Design team size isn't always an indication of business impact or a company's design maturity. **Many teams low on the maturity scale are large, and many teams displaying advanced benefits to their bottom line are small.** It's possible to dedicate a lot of resources to design and still see small returns if the design team, its processes, and its supporting structures aren't properly calibrated.

"Our company has approximately _____ designers."

Average number of designers



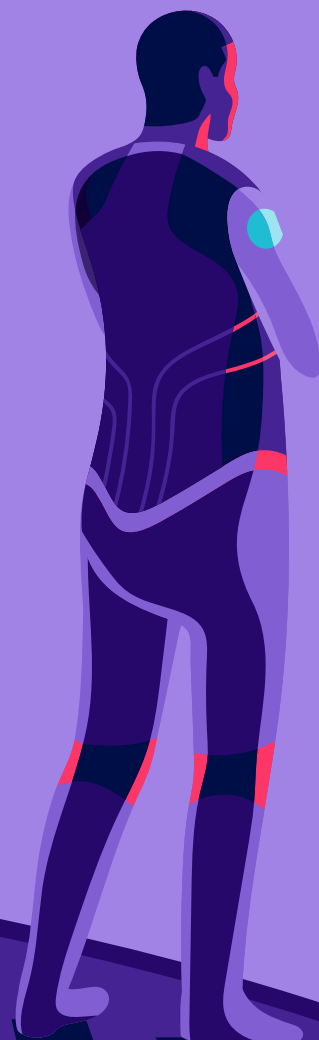
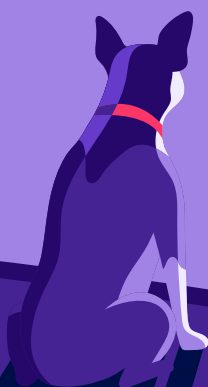
**Based on 2,090 respondents*



Maturity model

**"Things are only impossible
until they're not."**

- Captain Jean-Luc Picard



The maturity solar system

Today, a universe of organizations is leveraging design to drive business forward. But why is it that some companies' efforts are more influential than others? What makes them different? And what are the phases of change needed to deliver the highest results? We asked, and thousands of designers answered.

As we've already reviewed, design teams are working on most projects in 80% of companies. **But the top 5% of organizations are tackling design in a truly integrated way that is elevating strategy, increasing market share, and surging employee impact.**

Designer-to-developer ratios are at a healthier balance, design systems are commonly adopted, and user research is baked into most workflows in these superstars.

Understanding what differentiates the behaviors of these types of organizations is key to learning how your company can evolve and build a better design practice. And most companies are only just scratching the surface of what's possible. Get to know the phases of the new design maturity today.



Level 5: 5% Visionaries

Design is business strategy



Level 4: 12% Scientists

Design is a hypothesis and an experiment



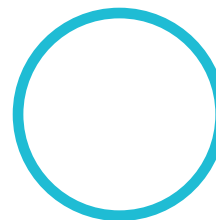
Level 3: 21% Architects

Design is a standardized scalable process



Level 2: 21% Connectors

Design is what happens in a workshop



Level 1: 41% Producers

Design is what happens on screens

Level 1

Producers

Design just makes it look good

Level 1 companies are focused only on the most visible aspects of design—the pixels on the screen. At this level, organizations make early attempts to create efficiency and consistent story through visual identity guidelines but neglect processes, collaboration, and advanced tools.

Average number of designers: 30

41% of companies

Key activities:

Wireframes

Design comps

Interactive prototypes



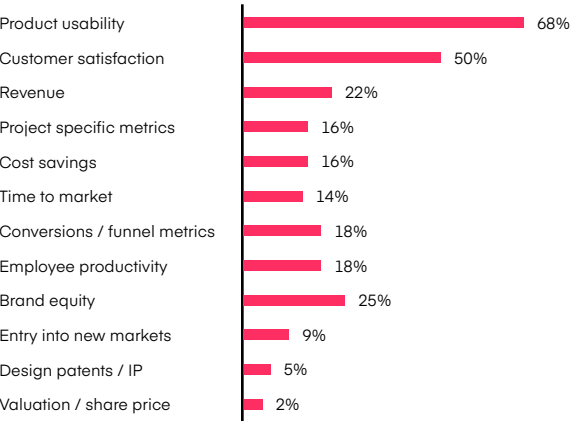
"Your eyes can deceive you. Don't trust them."

- Obi-Wan Kenobi

The conventional wisdom is that low design maturity comes from lack of resources. That's clearly not true, as you can see here. The issue is that Level 1 companies focus almost exclusively on screen design. Often in Level 1 companies, there's also a disconnect between what designers design and what developers build, symptomatic of a lack of cohesion between partners across the board. Companies can level up by incorporating more user research and collaboration into digital product design.

Collaborating across teams—including through workshops and online tools—and building out a user research program will give Level 1 companies what they need to get beyond the pixel and help their colleagues see that design is more than just a pretty picture.

"Our design team has had proven impact on: " (Level 1 companies)



Level snapshot



Level 2

Connectors

The workplace becomes a workshop

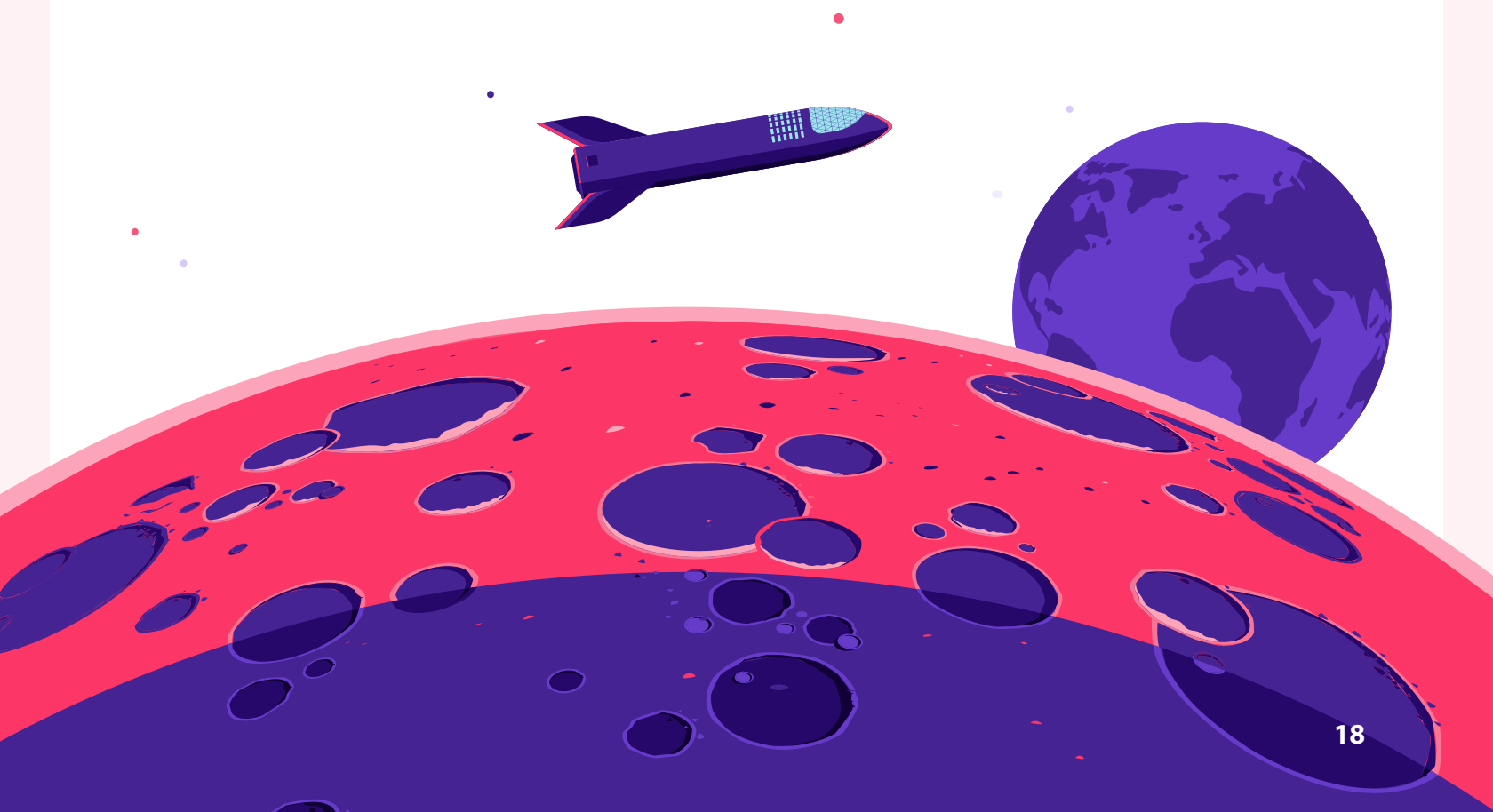
Design teams at Level 2 organizations have developed more collaborative processes, incorporating joint working sessions and integrated tooling with non-design peers. User research, user stories, usability testing, and personas are also more prevalent. Overall, there's more talk of design in the air—from executives who espouse its importance to employees who express more interest and empathy for customers.

Average number of designers: 12

21% of companies

Key activities:

- Workshops
- Rapid sketching
- Stakeholder input
- Integrations between designer and developer tools



"It's a fixer-upper of a planet, but we could make it work."

- Elon Musk

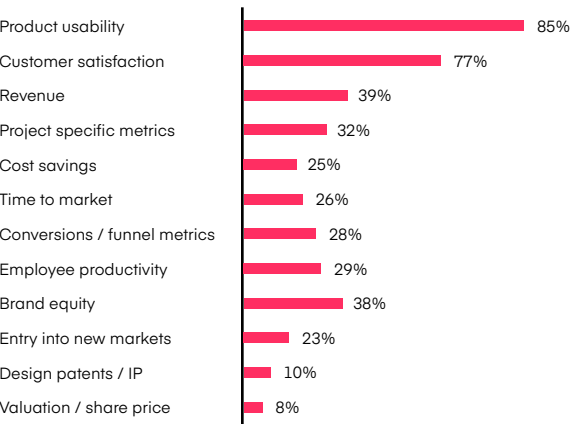
Level 2 companies are gaining momentum. They're conducting more user-informed design and more broadly engaging stakeholders and key partners, including developers. In fact, **over 50% of Level 2 companies make rapid sketching, joint working sessions, stakeholder input, and designer/developer tool integration regular features of the design process.** This success typically brings more demand though.

So how do Level 2 companies level up? Dig in on design systems, hiring semi-dedicated or dedicated people to fill the types of roles associated with a systematic approach, including designers, engineers, and product managers who focus exclusively on creating systems for design at scale.

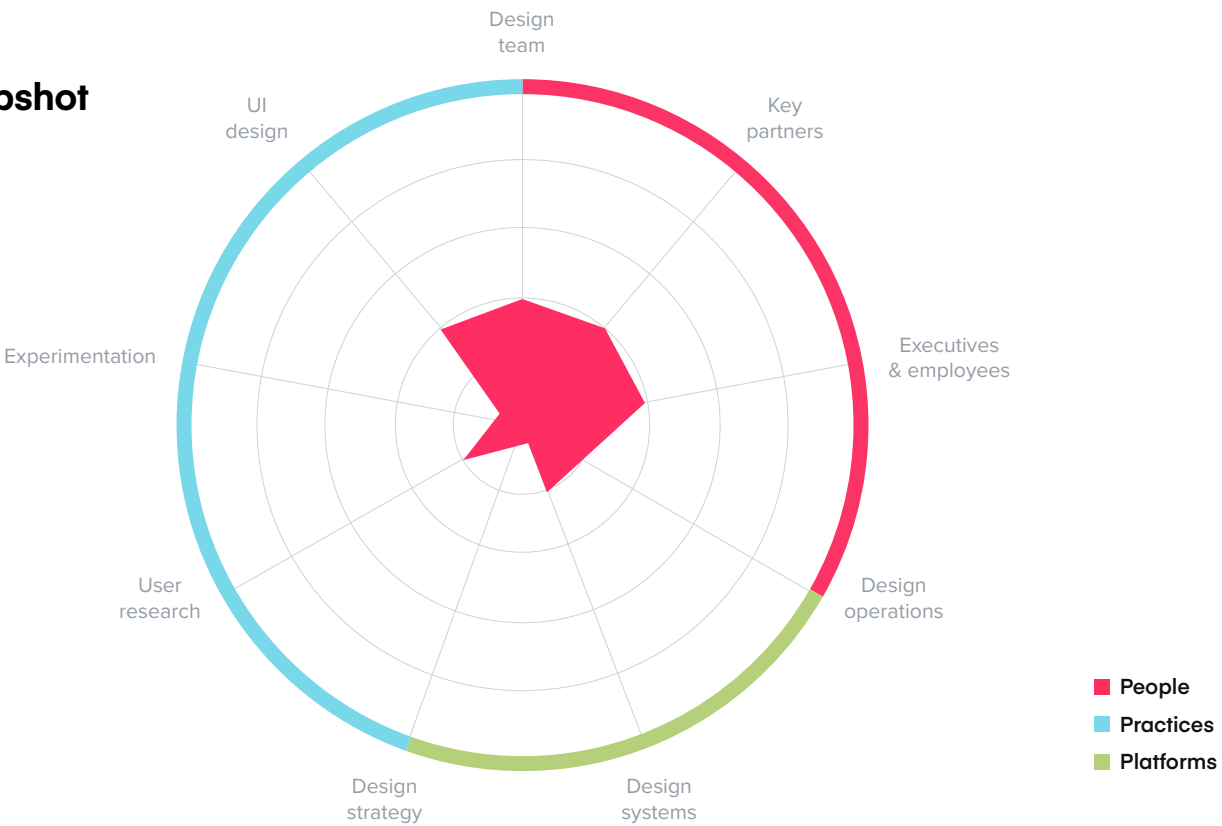
As more emphasis is put on design across the business, design systems, design operations, and the tools that enable them become mission critical.

"Our design team has had proven impact on: "

(Level 2 companies)



Level snapshot



Level 3

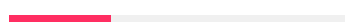
Architects

Design is a scalable operation

Formalizing design as a scalable function is a marquee trait for Level 3 businesses. They have moved beyond basic participatory design processes and have shared ownership, role clarity, joint accountability, and more documentation of their now more substantial design practices. This enables design to support more complex product ecosystems while integrating itself into equally complex internal operating structures.

Average number of designers: 54

21% of companies



Key activities:

- Daily standups
- Planning & prioritization
- Design briefs
- Written documentation



"Your focus determines your reality."

- Qui-Gon Jinn

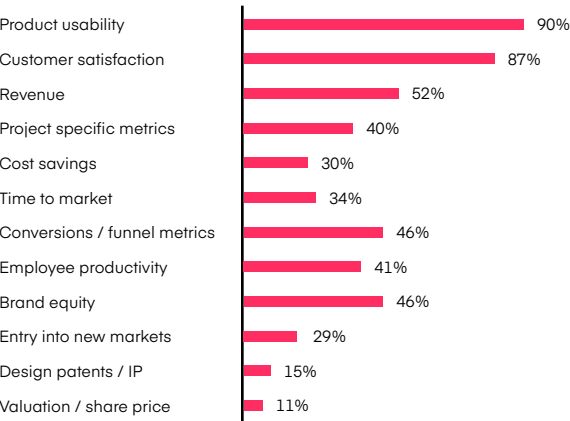
Level 3 companies have the largest design teams, which makes sense, since they tend to be more focused on the types of operational mechanisms that come along with larger teams. **At this point, teams are interested in clarifying roles between design, development, and product management, as well as incorporating more robust documentation processes to smooth the handoff between design and development.**

Level 3 companies can look very mature on paper. They're doing a lot of design, with operational efficiency to scale it broadly throughout the company. But how do they know if the work is effective? In many cases, they may not.

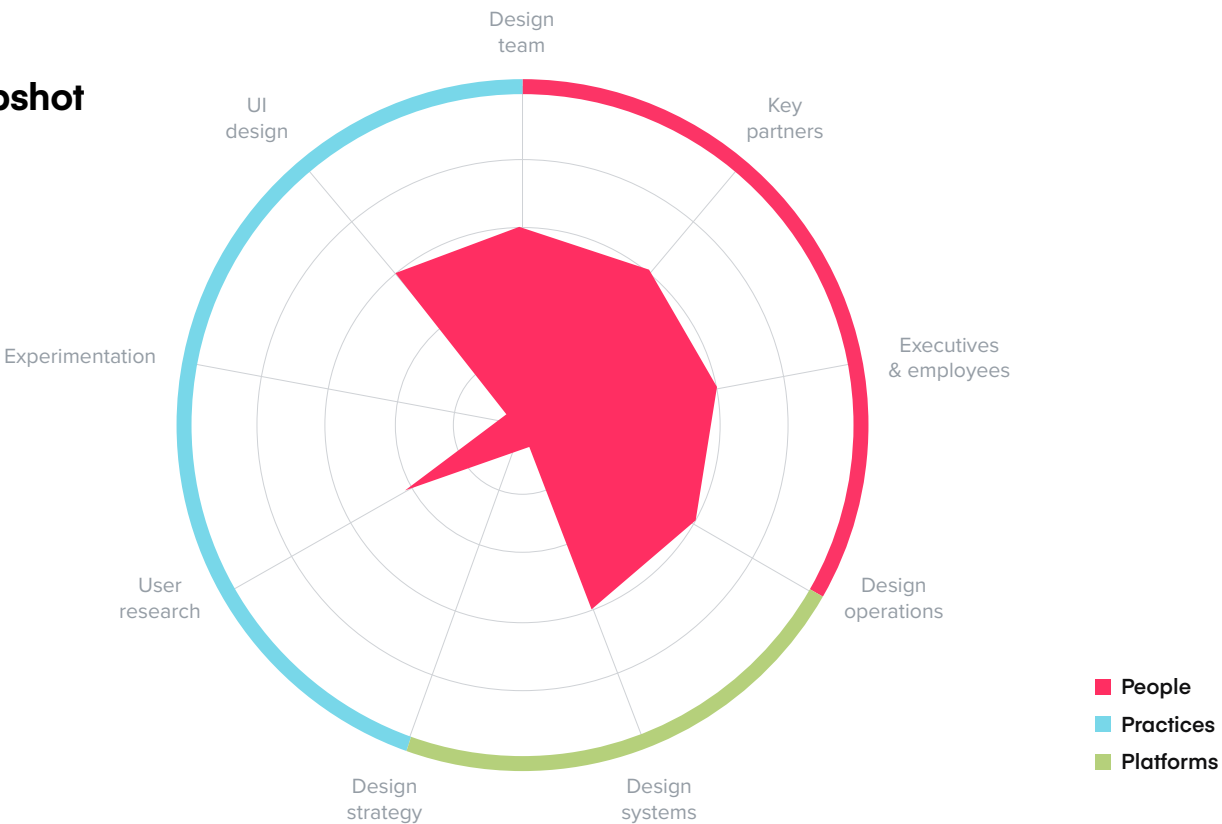
So how do they level up? To achieve the watershed in business benefits that comes with Level 4, **Level 3 companies need to focus on strengthening their experimentation practices, building in mechanisms and routines around developing hypotheses, running tests, and measuring results.**

"Our design team has had proven impact on: "

(Level 3 companies)



Level snapshot



Level 4

Scientists

Hypotheses and experimentation power design

Organizations at this level are masters of data-driven design. They have sophisticated practices for analytics, experimentation, recruiting for user research, and monitoring and measuring the success of specific efforts. They also have the beginnings of a design strategy practice, engaging in market research and vision development. In these companies, the design team is empowered to pursue opportunities it deems important. Executives are all in, publicly declaring the importance of design, as well as measuring and monitoring its impact on the business. To support all of this, design operations are fully formalized.

Average number of designers: 13

12% of companies

Key activities:

Concept testing

A/B tests

Analytics



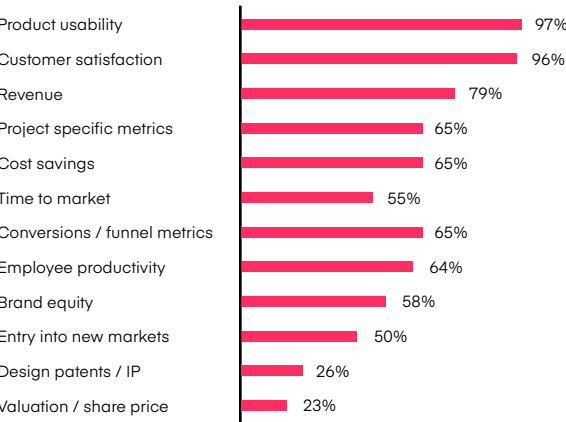
"To turn our back on the quest for knowledge is to perish."

- Frank Borman

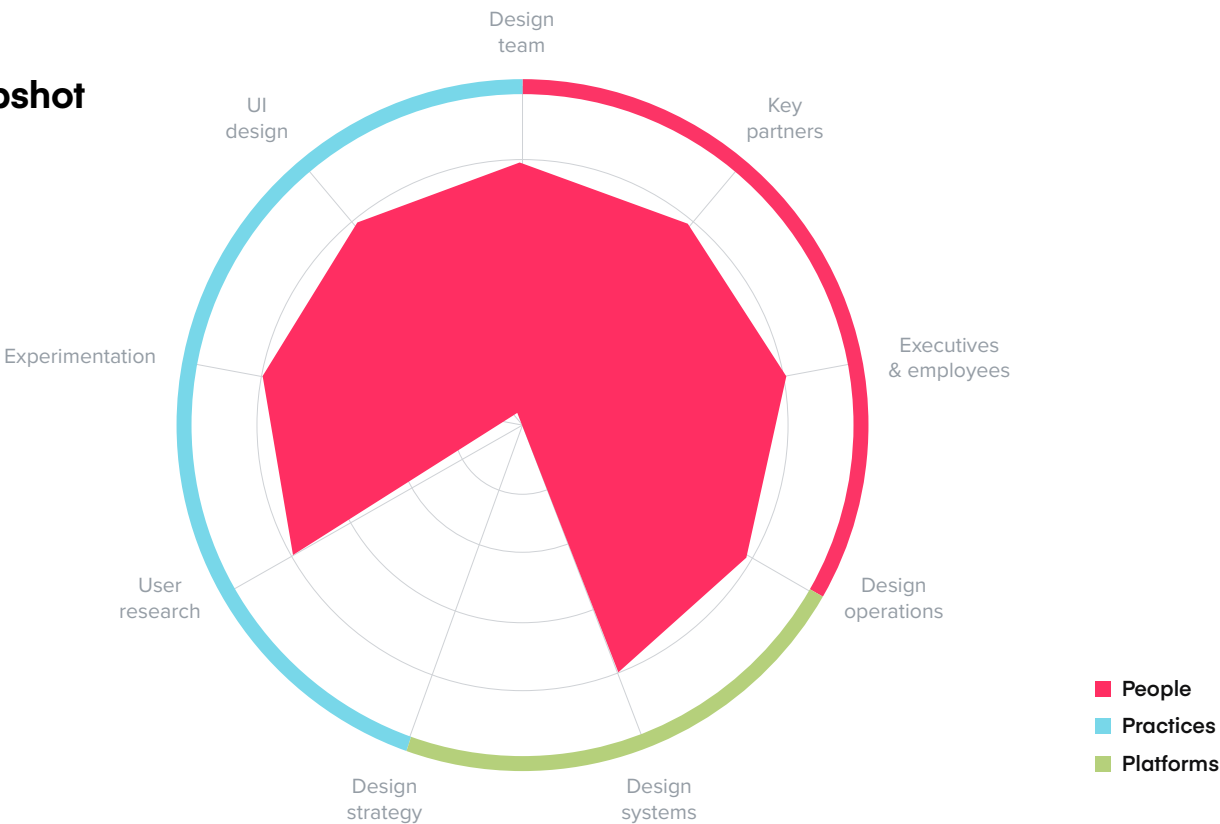
Something very different happens in Level 4 companies. Enabled by deep partnership with developers, product managers, and data analysts, design becomes a learning and decision-making tool. Across the organization, teams use data-driven approaches that integrate ideation, experiments, and analytics—and it pays off. **Level 4 is a transformative moment for design-driven business benefits, producing efficiency, cost savings, and project-specific benefits.**

For Level 4 companies to reach the upper echelon of Level 5, they have to make design core to their business strategy. The good news is they have all the pieces in place: the design team, the infrastructure and operations, and the testing and learning capabilities. **Level 4 enterprises need to apply those tools to new challenges in the business, bringing design thinking into the boardroom and employing design exploration to discover the next business opportunity.**

"Our design team has had proven impact on: " (Level 4 companies)



Level snapshot



Level 5

Visionaries

Design means business

Level 5 companies are robust in all dimensions of maturity, but what really separates them from others is design's involvement in strategy. Design brings a unique lens to strategy through exploratory user research techniques, trends and foresight research that assess product market fit, and the delivery of unified cross-platform strategies. As a result, Level 5 companies report that design has impact on the widest range of benefits, from employee productivity to growth in market share to the development of new intellectual property.

Average number of designers: 15

5% of companies

Key activities:

- Trendspotting and foresight
- Product market fit tests
- Vision artifacts
- Cross-platform strategies



"It's been a long way, but we're here."

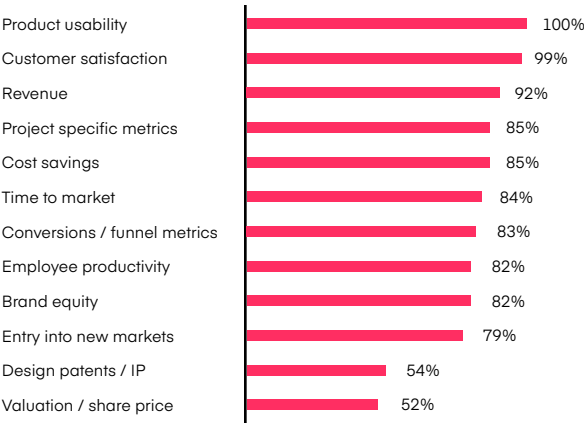
- Alan Shepard

In the top 5% of companies, design has become core to business strategy, impacting the most elusive business benefits of all—design IP and valuation. Skeptical executives may assume this kind of strategic design is only for digital disruptors like Lyft or Airbnb, surely not for them. They're not off the hook that easily. Level 5 companies are found in every industry, from banking to business logistics, education to entertainment. They're the ones using technology and design to redefine the standards for customer experience and business process excellence.

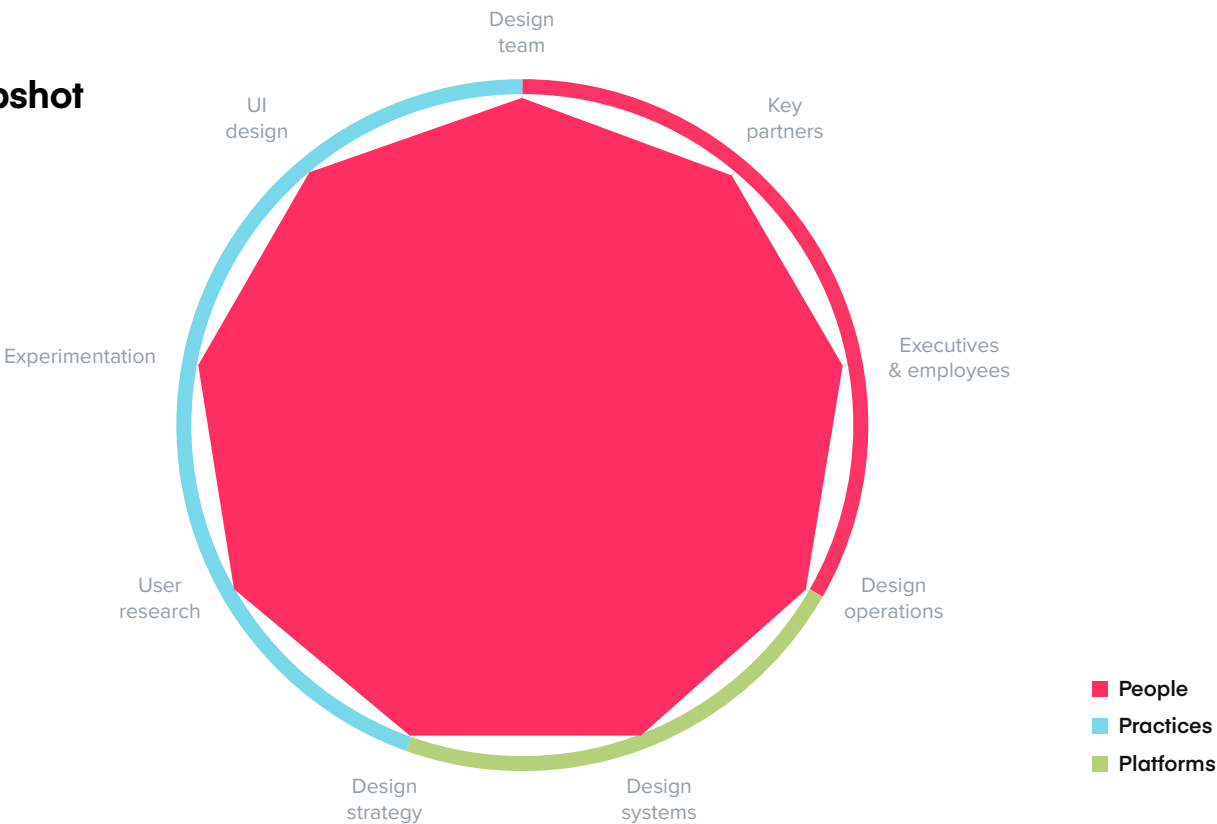
Level 5 companies put a lot of heat on industry incumbents, either by directly taking their market share or by gradually changing customer expectations. **So regardless of their level, companies need to pay attention to the Level 5s in their industries to understand the challenges coming their way. Better still if companies can cultivate their own Level 5 design practices, pursuing customer-focused opportunities that will set them aside from the competition.**

"Our design team has had proven impact on: "

(Level 5 companies)



Level snapshot



Key trends in the market

by industry
by company size
by region

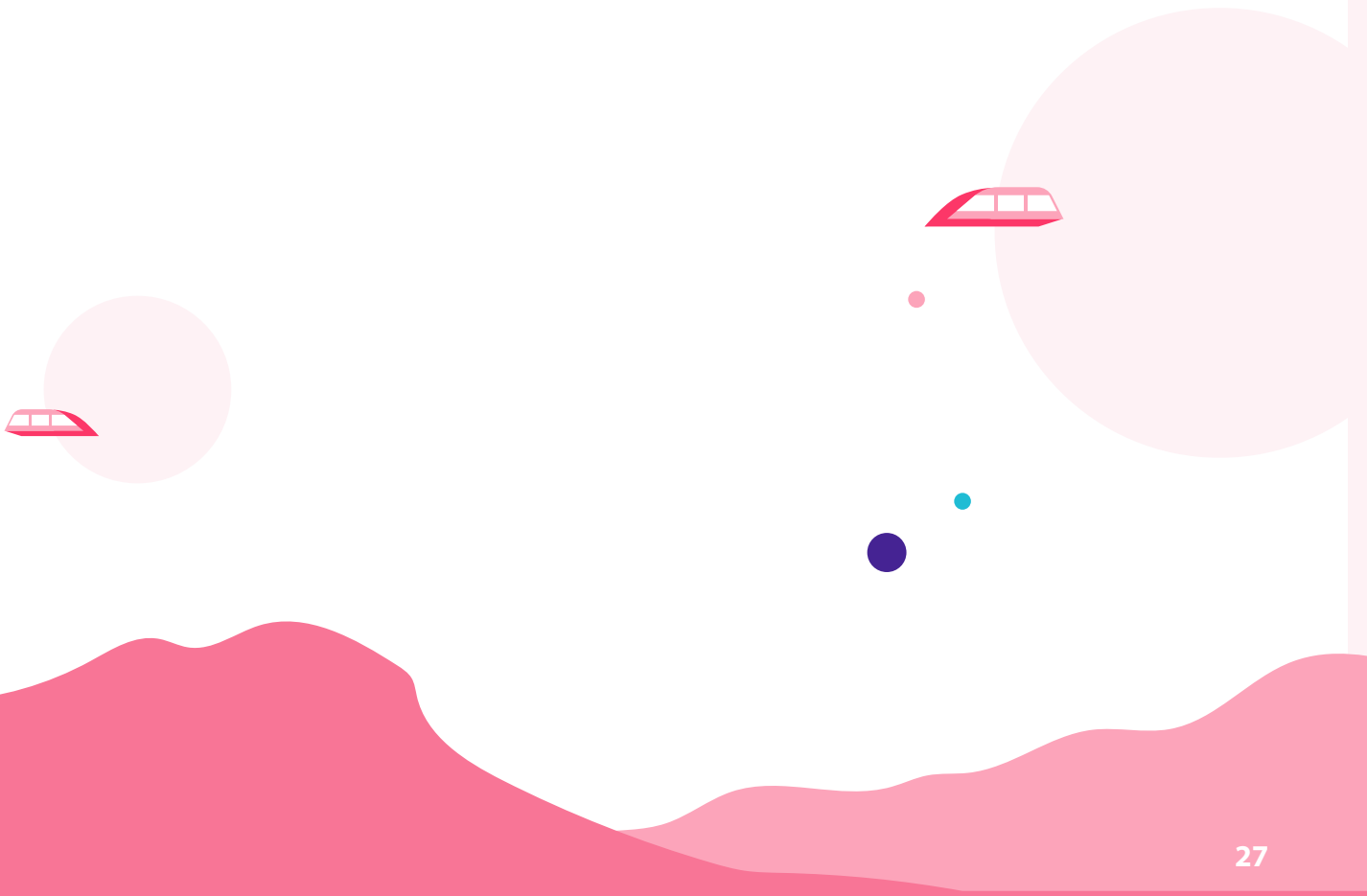


Maturity by industry

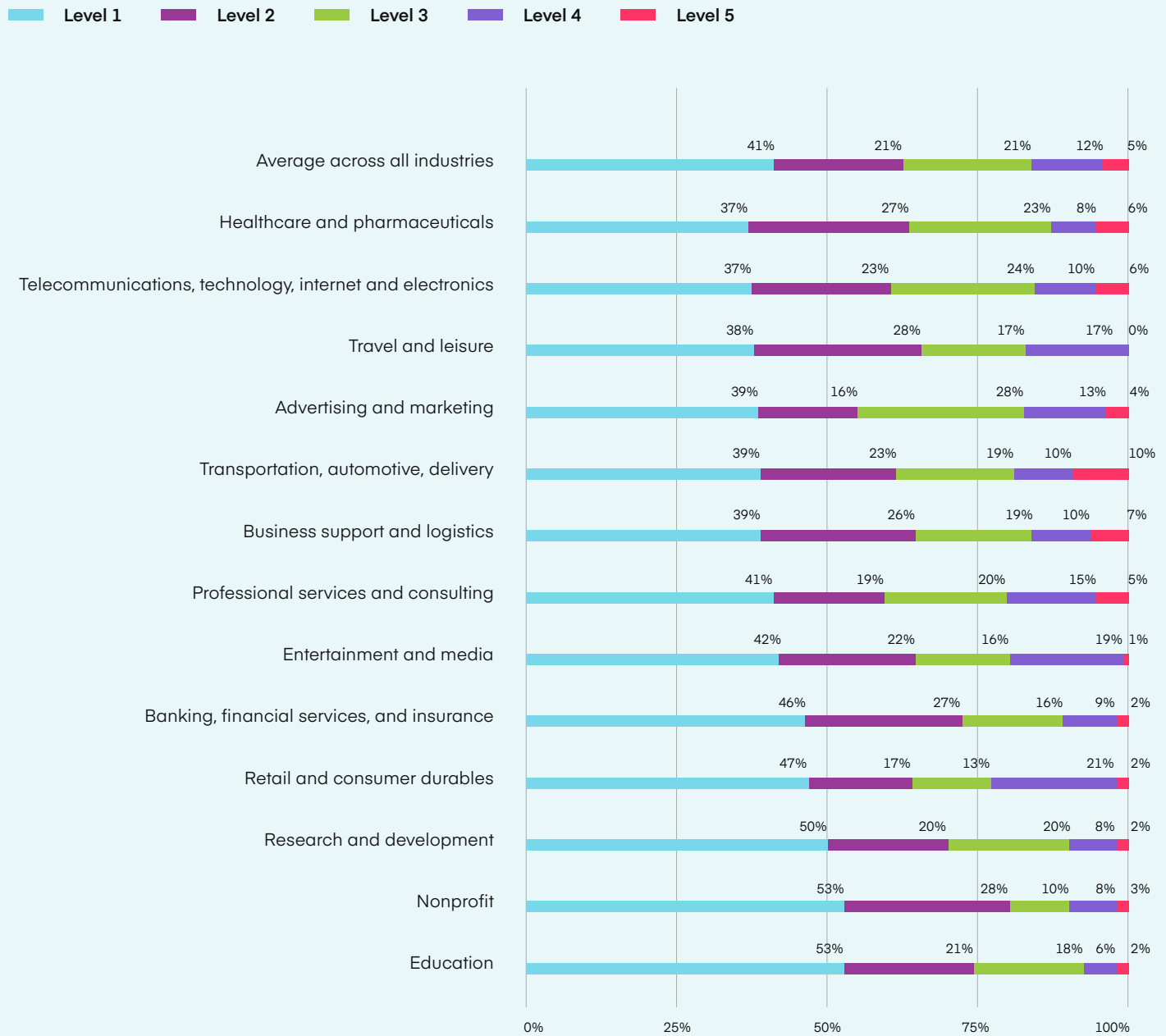
Some industries lean toward lower maturity, some tend to have higher than average maturity, and some exist in the messy middle, with the bulk of companies hovering around Level 3 or 4.

Leading industries include healthcare, pharma, IT, advertising, transportation, and automotive. These industries have fewer low maturity companies than the average overall.

Industries with the most room for improvement include education, nonprofit, research & development, retail, consumer durables, and (surprisingly) banking.



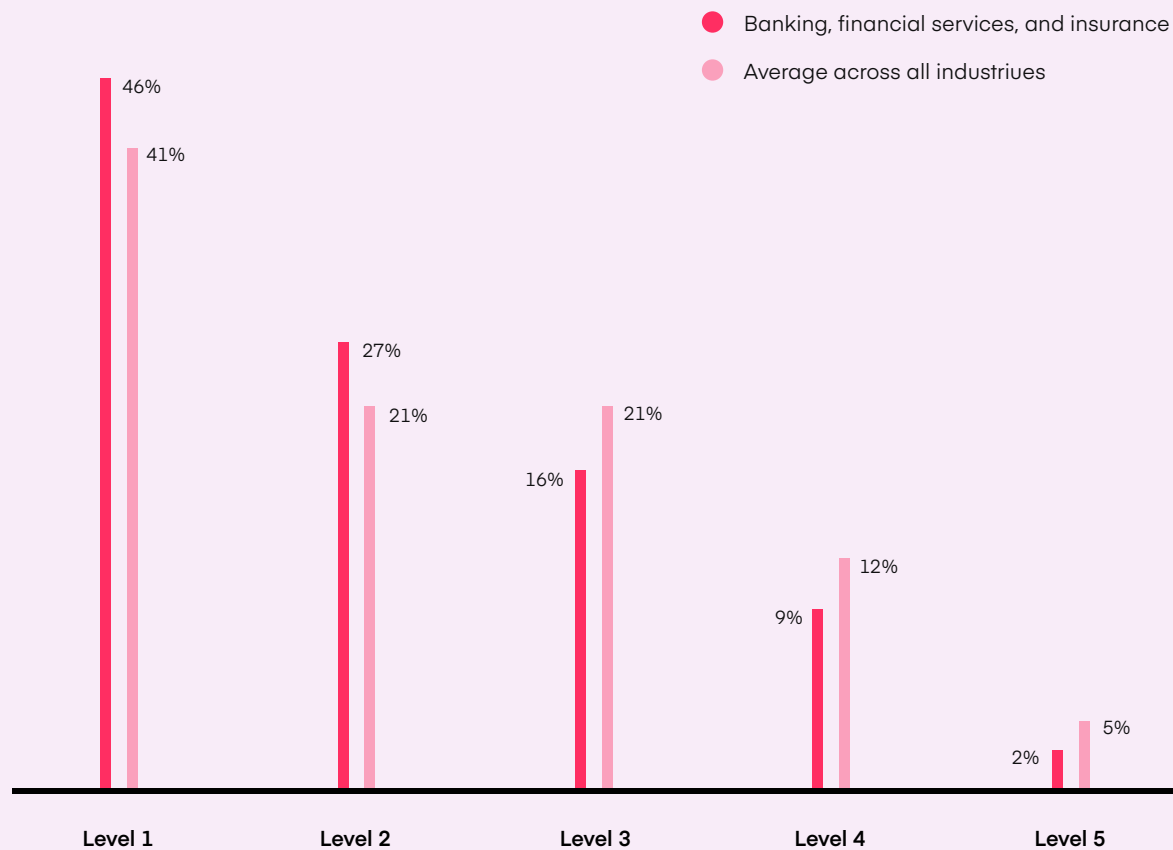
Design maturity by industry



*Percentages have been rounded and may not equal 100%.

Journey into banking, financial services, and insurance

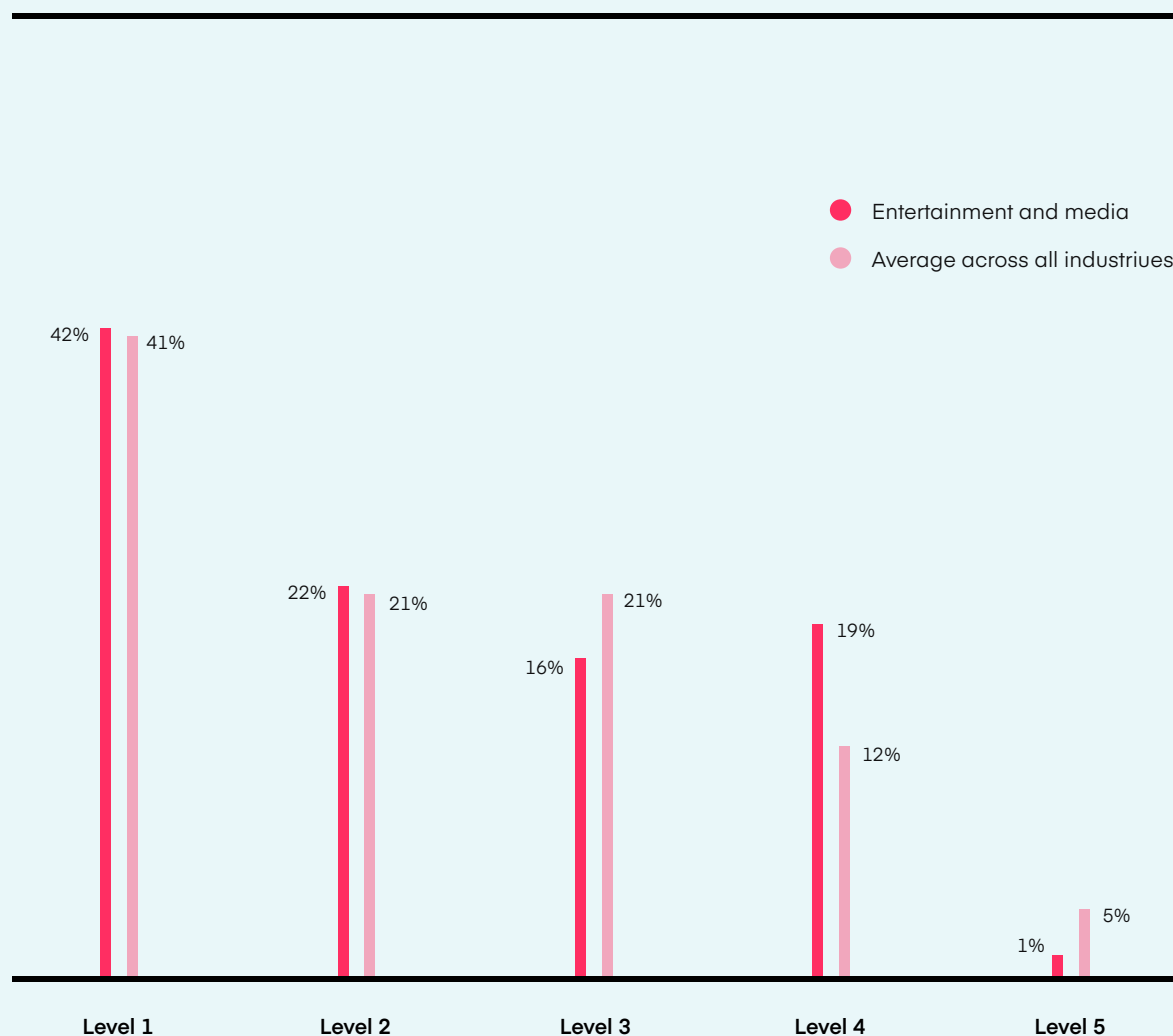
The banking industry is known for its large UX teams, yet it lags when it comes to design maturity. **This is a prime example of how investing in resources has diminished effects without incorporating design into business strategy overall.**



**Percentages have been rounded and may not equal 100%.*

Journey into entertainment and media

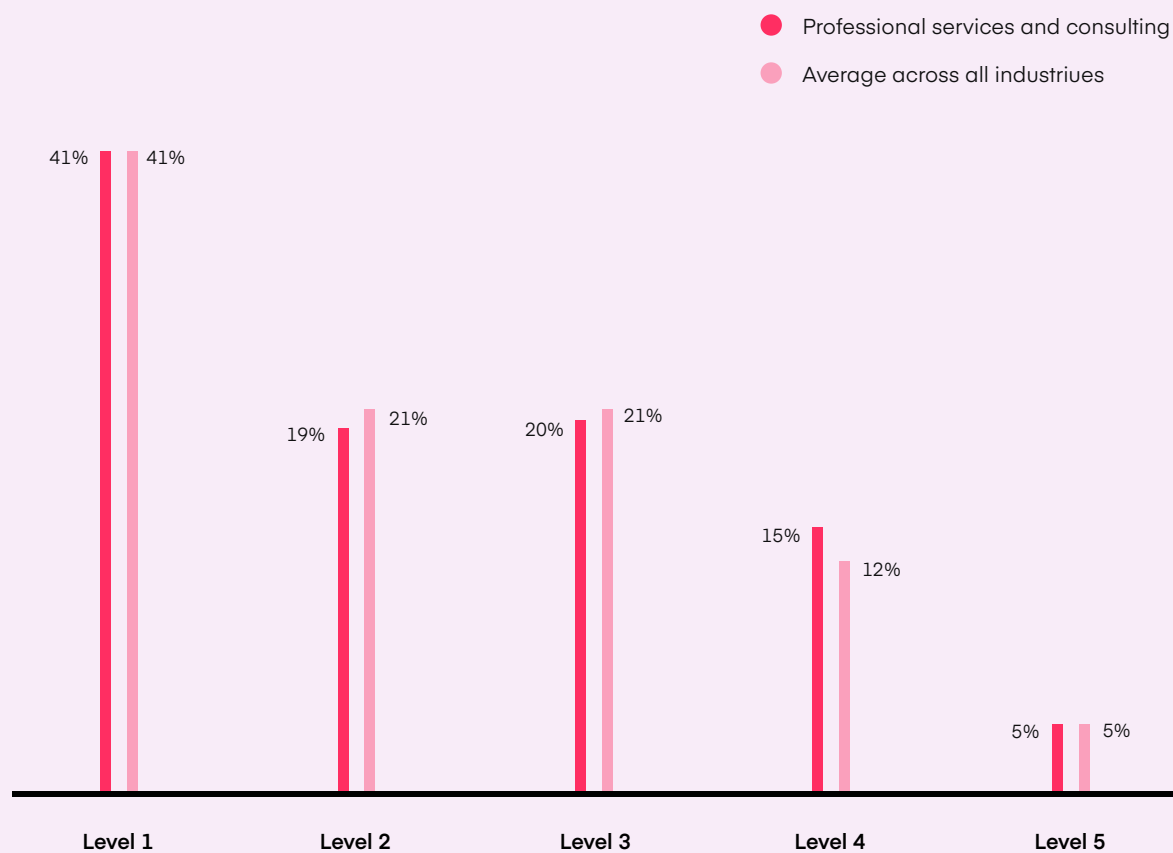
Entertainment and media skew less mature than the average overall. Still, the number of Level 4 companies is over 50% higher than average. What might this mean? While most entertainment and media companies are hewing to outdated design approaches, **a sizable and competitive subset are pushing industry norms forward through experimentation, analytics, A/B and beta testing, and design measurement.**



**Percentages have been rounded and may not equal 100%.*

Journey into professional services and consulting

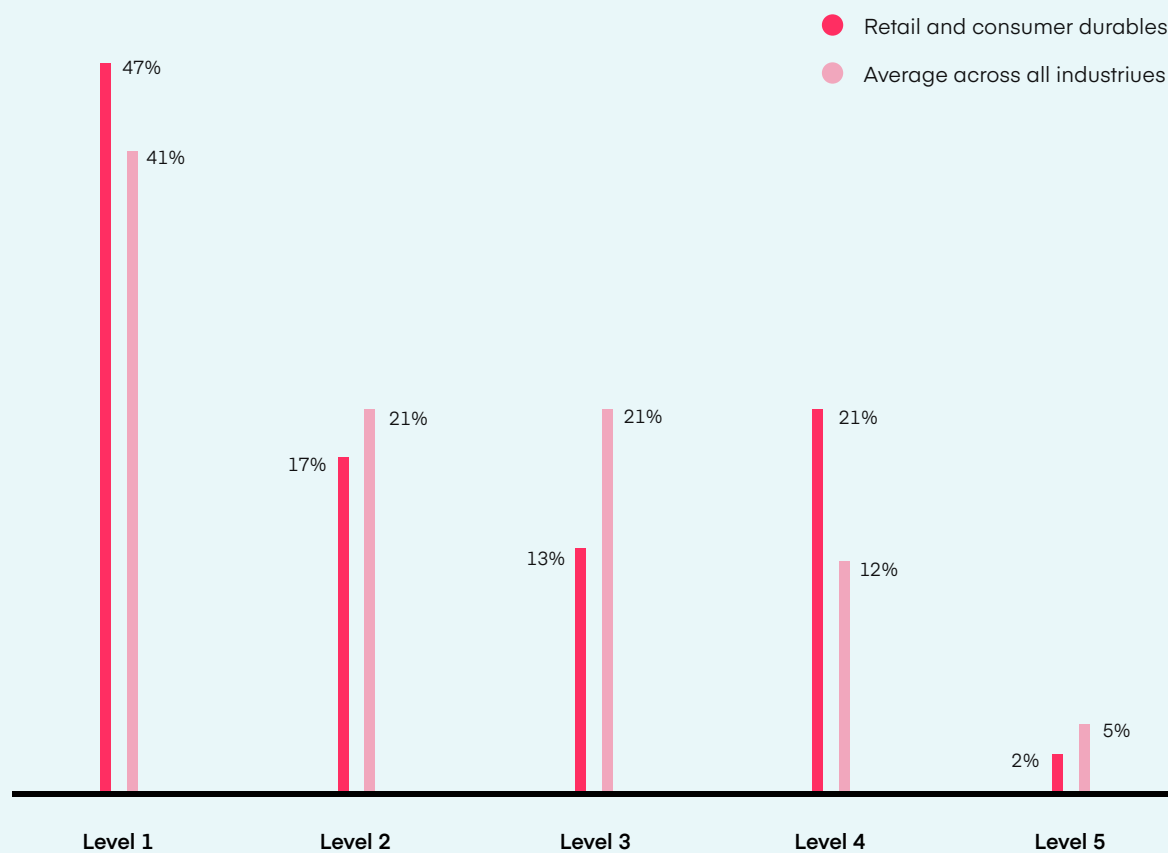
It's often assumed that professional services firms have the luxury of more advanced design practices, while enterprise design is weighed down by scale and inertia. Not necessarily: Professional services firms have a maturity distribution that's markedly similar to the average overall. **Just as in other industries, professional services includes a few design leaders and its fair share of laggards.**



**Percentages have been rounded and may not equal 100%.*

Journey into retail and consumer durables

Design maturity in retail and consumer durables is polarized, with 15% more Level 1 companies than average, but 75% more Level 4 companies than average. This industry has been hit hard by disruptive forces like digital transformation, a changing global supply chain, and the shuttering of brick and mortar. Its volatility is evident in its design maturity distribution, where **a meaningful percent of the industry has adopted experimentation and data-driven design to evolve with change, but many are falling behind**. It's a cautionary tale for every industry.



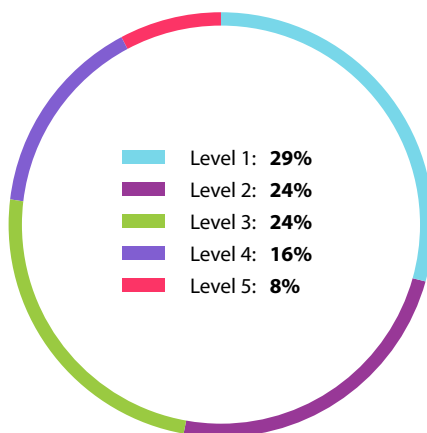
**Percentages have been rounded and may not equal 100%.*

Maturity by company size

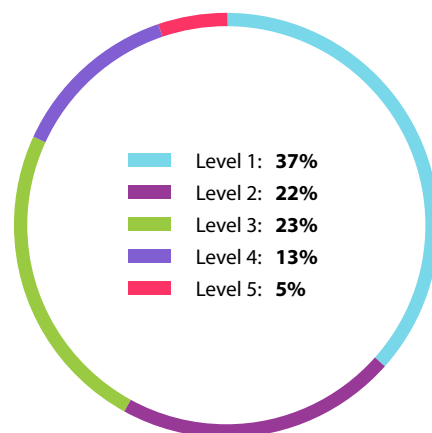
Larger organizations face a greater challenge in reaching design maturity. SMBs (10–99 employees) are twice as likely and micro-businesses (fewer than 10 employees) are three times as likely as large enterprises (1,000+ employees) to be Level 5.

Because of their complexity and scale, enterprises can be at a disadvantage relative to smaller, newer challengers, who may have prioritized design from their inception. For this reason, larger organizations have to be particularly thoughtful about how they integrate design into their business, focusing on strategy, collaboration, experimentation, and quality at scale.

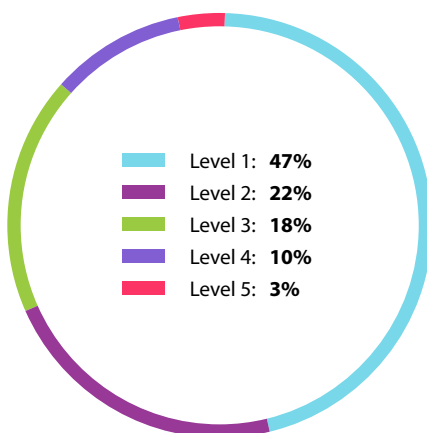
Micro (fewer than 10 employees)



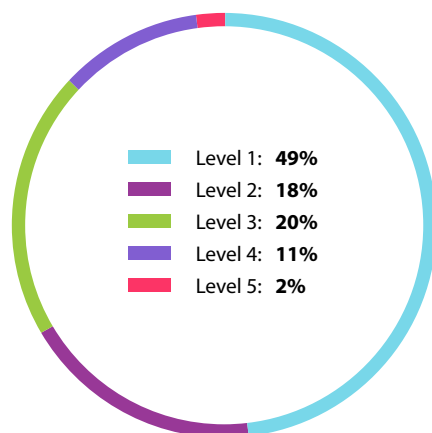
SMB (10-99 employees)



Mid-market (100-999 employees)



Large enterprise (1,000+ employees)



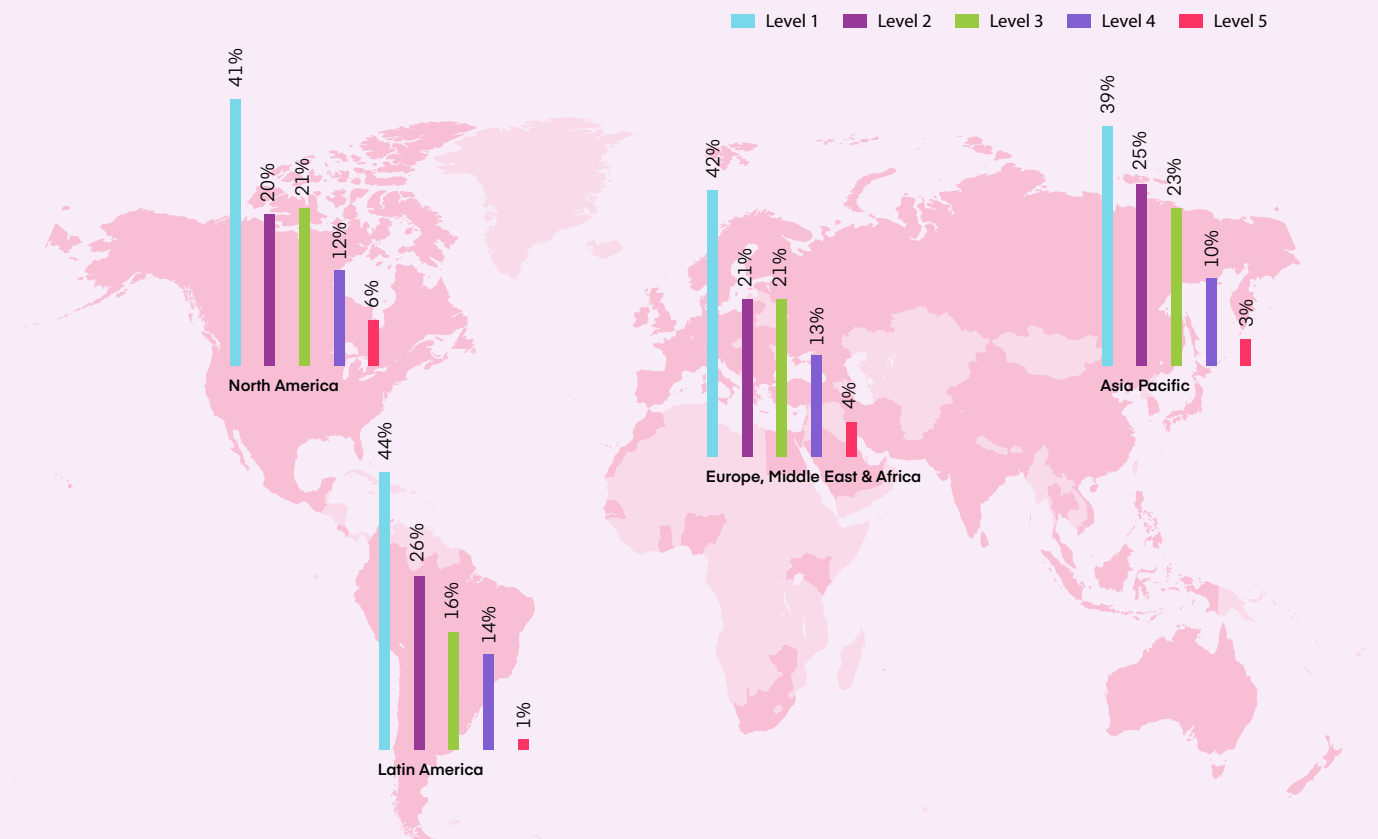
**Percentages have been rounded and may not equal 100%.*

Maturity by region

Design maturity is distributed fairly evenly around the world, with large percentages of companies on the low end of the maturity spectrum and significantly fewer high maturity companies in every region.

Europe and North America, similar in terms of overall maturity distribution, lead the rest of the world in design maturity. Latin America is the least mature region, with higher percentages of low design maturity companies and just 1% of companies at Level 5.

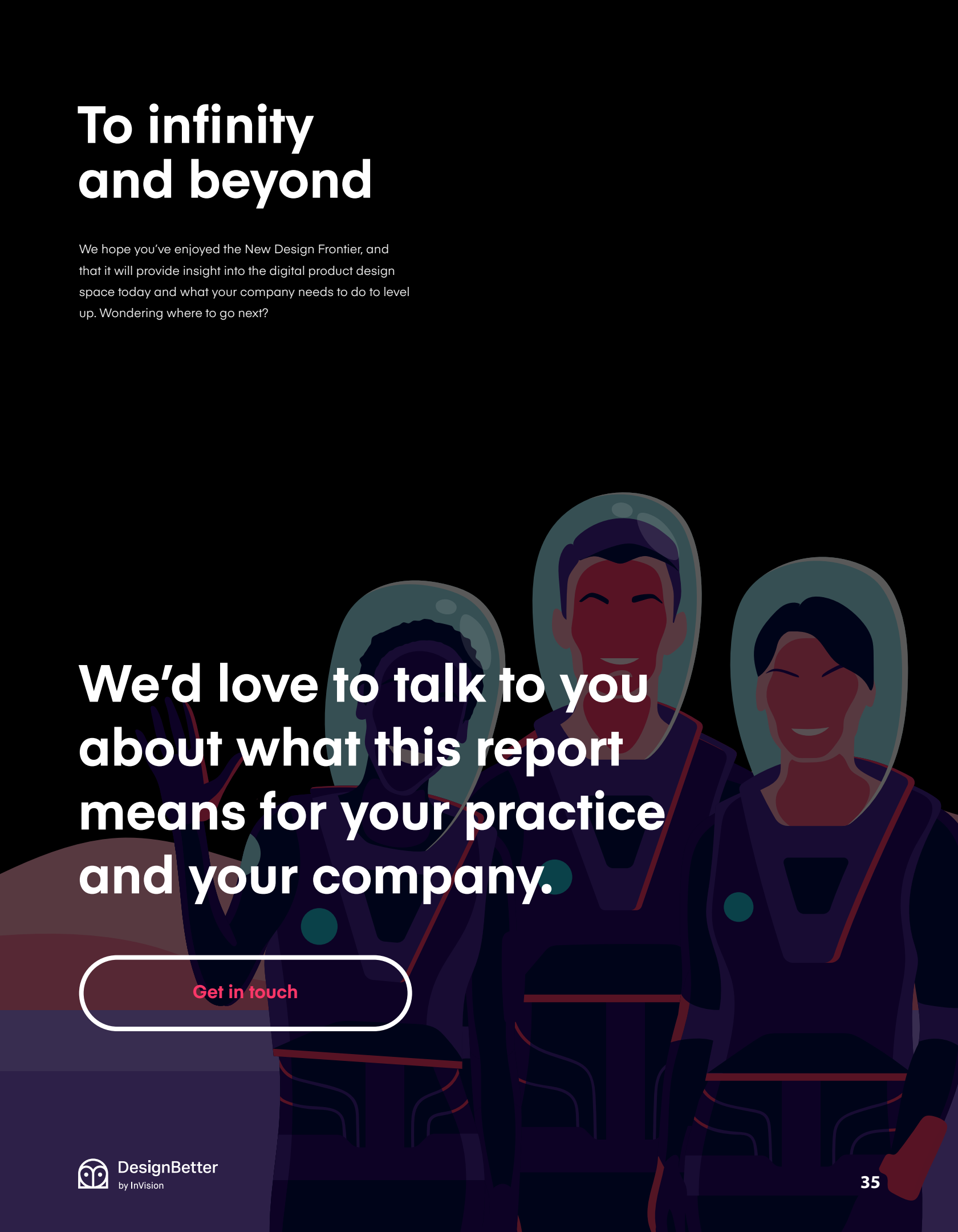
Asia Pacific is in an interesting middle ground, less likely to be low maturity, but also less likely to be high maturity. Asia Pacific clumps around Levels 2 and 3, suggesting some operational excellence but fewer of the human-centered, innovation-oriented practices that are driving business results in companies in North America and Europe.



**Percentages have been rounded and may not equal 100%.*

To infinity and beyond

We hope you've enjoyed the New Design Frontier, and that it will provide insight into the digital product design space today and what your company needs to do to level up. Wondering where to go next?

An illustration of three astronauts in dark blue space suits with red accents, floating in space. The astronaut on the left is waving. In the background, a reddish-brown planet is visible on the left, and a bright blue ringed planet is on the right. The overall theme is space exploration and future design.

We'd love to talk to you about what this report means for your practice and your company.

[Get in touch](#)



DesignBetter
by InVision

Appendix

Mission operative: people, practices, platforms

The highest-performing organizations all have the same thing in common—a laser focus on the three Ps: people, practices, and platforms.

As denoted by the green shading, a majority of Level 5 companies, those benefiting from design the most, invest in the development of their teams, the career paths of their design leaders, and the operationalization of design.

They incorporate design in strategy and product roadmaps, and they invest in the tools needed to keep their business pushing forward, with design as its North Star.

“If you wish to make an apple pie from scratch, you must first invent the universe.”

- Carl Sagan

People

People are the foundation of a company's ability to produce great digital products. While adequate resourcing and skills on the design team are important, in more mature companies, design transcends borders. Executives, key product partners, and even the average employee all contribute to bringing well-designed products to life.

Design team	lvl 1	lvl 2	lvl 3	lvl 4	lvl 5
A record of promoting designers to leadership and senior positions	12%	20%	26%	41%	60%
Funding for ongoing training	30%	37%	36%	48%	63%
See design and customer-centricity reflected in the physical space	12%	23%	31%	40%	67%
Have a hiring process that enables hiring high-quality design talent (e.g., knowledgeable recruiters, good job descriptions, etc.)	20%	31%	35%	53%	58%
Design work is shared in all hands meetings, important executive meetings, and other influential gatherings	38%	55%	63%	78%	89%
Have design generalists (e.g., UX designers, product designers) and visual designers on staff	86%	91%	95%	96%	98%
Key partners	lvl 1	lvl 2	lvl 3	lvl 4	lvl 5
Key partners are well-integrated into the design process (e.g. participating in design sprints)	17%	32%	48%	74%	96%
Product/feature ideas are jointly developed and owned between design and key partners	22%	40%	53%	74%	95%
Design works with key partners in the same/integrated software	27%	39%	54%	67%	90%
Design has clear division of roles and responsibilities with key partners	43%	50%	57%	68%	76%
Design has joint working sessions with key partners (e.g., workshops, stand-ups, etc.)	32%	55%	63%	80%	97%
Design leaders are peers with product management and engineering leaders	36%	53%	63%	77%	96%
Design sits together with key partners	40%	58%	70%	76%	86%
Design shares priorities and goals with key partners	42%	63%	76%	94%	99%
Design is well-integrated in the product development process	41%	74%	84%	94%	100%
Executives & employees	lvl 1	lvl 2	lvl 3	lvl 4	lvl 5
Employees receive design-oriented training (e.g., design thinking, human centered design, etc.)	12%	18%	22%	35%	54%
Executives evaluate and incentivize design-centric behavior	13%	21%	31%	45%	66%

Executives monitor and measure design's contribution to the business	18%	26%	41%	53%	61%
Executives empower the design group to identify and pursue unplanned or unrequested ideas	22%	35%	49%	58%	80%
Executives talk about the value of design externally	34%	43%	48%	66%	80%
Employees participate in the design process through online tools	24%	31%	52%	62%	77%
Employees understand what human-centered design is	27%	39%	53%	68%	82%
Executives prioritize decisions that lead to the best design/customer experience	25%	46%	53%	71%	83%
Employees understand why human-centered design is valuable	25%	42%	59%	68%	85%
Top executives allocate appropriate resources for design	30%	43%	55%	66%	84%
Top executives get personally involved in the design process	34%	47%	57%	64%	85%
Employees participate in the design process in person	30%	50%	61%	82%	95%
Executives call attention to the design team's work	39%	48%	64%	67%	87%
Employees participate in user/customer research	28%	51%	60%	75%	91%
Executives involve senior design leaders in critical decisions	33%	51%	61%	76%	88%
Executives talk about the value of design internally	49%	62%	77%	81%	89%
Employees have a good sense of customers and their needs	51%	64%	70%	81%	87%

Practices

Design practices at Level 5 look radically different from Level 1. Whereas a Level 1 company focuses almost exclusively on UI design, Level 5 companies have a practice of design that includes user research to understand customers and their needs, experimentation to place bets and pick winning solutions, and design strategies to apply the power of design to core business priorities like digital transformation.

User research	lvl 1	lvl 2	lvl 3	lvl 4	lvl 5
Guerilla user research	18%	25%	30%	34%	51%
Co-creation with customers	16%	25%	34%	47%	65%
Surveys	28%	37%	43%	57%	61%
Customer interviews	34%	50%	57%	70%	85%
User stories and epics	38%	50%	57%	66%	80%

Usability tests	37%	51%	64%	76%	86%
Personas and user scenarios	38%	53%	63%	73%	88%
User / customer journeys	40%	56%	66%	81%	87%

Design strategy	lvl 1	lvl 2	lvl 3	lvl 4	lvl 5
Trendspotting & foresight research	9%	13%	23%	26%	54%
Design-specific measures established at the start of an initiative	8%	16%	20%	37%	58%
Unified cross-platform strategy	9%	17%	25%	33%	62%
Lean-style experiments (e.g., dry tests, landing pages, etc.)	13%	19%	30%	40%	65%
Vision artifacts (e.g., storyboards, videos)	20%	24%	34%	49%	71%
Tracking financial KPIs such as revenue and profit	23%	30%	36%	45%	66%
Content strategy	24%	32%	37%	51%	75%
Market research and analysis	22%	32%	41%	56%	73%
Competitive analysis	31%	37%	53%	58%	74%
Design strategy	37%	54%	63%	74%	88%

Experimentation	lvl 1	lvl 2	lvl 3	lvl 4	lvl 5
Measurement and reporting on design outcomes	9%	17%	25%	37%	57%
Constant monitoring of user behavior and satisfaction	10%	21%	34%	40%	63%
Beta tests	13%	24%	37%	45%	63%
Mechanisms to recruit customers for research	19%	29%	33%	45%	64%
Mechanisms to conduct experiments	19%	30%	35%	53%	70%
A/B or multivariate tests	22%	28%	39%	58%	58%
Tracking targeted metrics determined for each project	23%	29%	39%	53%	67%
Tracking funnel and conversion metrics	28%	30%	38%	54%	53%
Concept testing	21%	32%	47%	56%	77%
Mechanisms to track data about users' behaviors	26%	24%	43%	59%	74%
Tracking the results of tests and experiments (e.g., A/B, beta, etc.)	34%	38%	47%	66%	67%

UI design	lvl 1	lvl 2	lvl 3	lvl 4	lvl 5
Accessibility review	16%	26%	27%	40%	54%
Motion / microinteraction design	17%	26%	36%	44%	59%
Structured design critiques	16%	28%	38%	52%	75%
Ideation workshops	26%	40%	45%	62%	75%
Task flow design	30%	41%	48%	56%	70%
Jobs to be done	36%	40%	44%	53%	66%
Copy and microcopy writing	35%	42%	51%	64%	71%
Written documentation (e.g., product requirements documents)	32%	49%	55%	58%	75%
Design briefs	38%	47%	53%	64%	74%
Information architecture	36%	49%	60%	67%	83%
Exploration of multiple design concepts	37%	51%	65%	74%	87%
Stakeholder input	44%	55%	62%	71%	86%
Rapid sketching	44%	56%	63%	74%	87%
Design principles	42%	60%	66%	80%	89%
Visual design comps	56%	64%	73%	78%	84%
Interactive prototypes	59%	73%	80%	88%	90%
Wireframes	75%	83%	86%	93%	95%

Platforms

Robust design practices and an engaged organization don't just happen; they're enabled by planning, coordination, and supporting systems. More mature companies formalize those enablers through design operations and design systems, which work together to make design happen more efficiently and at scale.

Design operations	lvl 1	lvl 2	lvl 3	lvl 4	lvl 5
Annual planning within the design organization for adequate headcount, budget, etc.	11%	22%	22%	33%	63%

Tracking design team behaviors (e.g., speed, number of experiments, user exposure hours)	19%	25%	32%	42%	53%
Retrospectives and post-mortems	18%	32%	38%	43%	70%
A defined charter, including mission, values, and principles	25%	35%	38%	54%	61%
Prioritization criteria to determine what projects the design org works on	23%	37%	48%	52%	75%
Feature planning and prioritization	29%	44%	58%	67%	83%
Daily standups	34%	43%	52%	55%	74%
A standardized set of design tools chosen for capabilities and interoperability	42%	49%	62%	69%	79%
Tracking customer satisfaction (e.g., NPS, SUS)	46%	56%	58%	70%	73%
Design systems	lvl 1	lvl 2	lvl 3	lvl 4	lvl 5
A dedicated team to maintain the design system	16%	23%	26%	36%	50%
Code snippets, APIs, microservices, etc.	18%	28%	29%	34%	53%
Interaction patterns across the product suite and across multiple channels	16%	26%	27%	47%	52%
Content/editorial guidelines	28%	35%	30%	46%	52%
Application of elements from the design system	24%	35%	48%	50%	71%
Revisiting previously launched work and making continuous improvements	23%	39%	49%	59%	76%
An online tool that documents the design system and is accessible to others	30%	40%	45%	53%	59%
Updating elements in the design system	30%	51%	59%	66%	78%
Integrations between designer and developer tools (e.g., JIRA, Inspect, etc.)	41%	52%	59%	67%	78%
UI best practices (accessibility, internationalization, designing for web vs. mobile, etc.)	44%	60%	65%	80%	82%
Design principles (brand values, purpose, objective, product principles)	44%	59%	67%	79%	73%
Visual identity guidelines (voice and tone, color palette, fonts, etc.)	77%	81%	84%	94%	94%
Style guides, patterns, design language system	61%	76%	83%	89%	96%

Your authors

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